# SAFE

Following a tested recipe for high-acid foods like fruit jam ensures the right acidity and processing time to prevent spoilage and unsafe bacteria growth. Proper headspace and boiling water bath processing are critical for safety. This method destroys molds, yeasts, and most bacteria, making the product safe for home storage.

*Source: SP 50-1000 Turkey basics*

# NOT SAFE

Raw poultry stored above 40°F for more than 2 hours is unsafe due to rapid bacterial growth in the danger zone (40-140°F). A foul odor and sticky texture also indicate spoilage. Consuming it risks foodborne illness.

*Source: SP 50-814 Summer food safety*

# IT DEPENDS

Freezing home-canned low-acid vegetables is safe only if they were pressure canned initially to destroy Clostridium botulinum spores. If processed only in a boiling water bath, freezing does not eliminate spores and the food may be unsafe. Confirm processing method before freezing.

*Source: SP 50-695 Safety of canned food that freezes*

# SAFE

Following a tested recipe with appropriate headspace, using a boiling water canner for high-acid fruit like peaches, and proper cooling without retightening lids ensures safe processing. Using new lids and processing for full recommended time prevents spoilage and unsafe conditions.

*Source: PNW 199 Canning fruits*

# NOT SAFE

Reusing old lids can prevent proper sealing because the sealing compound degrades after one use. Cloudy juice and bubbles inside jars are signs of spoilage. Improper seals increase risk of microbial growth and unsafe food. Such jars should be refrigerated and used quickly or discarded.

*Source: PNW 199 Canning fruits*

# IT DEPENDS

Asian pears have borderline acidity and require adding acid (such as lemon juice) to be safe when boiling water canning. Processing times and altitude adjustments must also be accurate. Without these specifics, safety cannot be assured. Proper acidification and time adjustments are critical to prevent microbial growth.

*Source: PNW 199 Canning fruits*

# SAFE

Following a tested recipe that includes the correct amount of acid (like bottled lemon juice or vinegar), and processing the salsa as instructed ensures the acidity is sufficient to prevent botulism. Using fresh, ripe tomatoes and following processing guidelines precisely is critical to safety.

*Source: PNW 395 Salsa recipes for canning*

# NOT SAFE

Tomatoes that are overripe or from frost-damaged vines lose acidity, which is necessary for safe boiling water canning. Without adding acid, botulism spores might survive. Not acidifying and using low-quality tomatoes can result in an unsafe product.

*Source: PNW 395 Salsa recipes for canning*

# IT DEPENDS

Safety depends on whether the salsa's acidity (pH) is low enough to prevent botulism growth. Without a tested recipe or lab analysis, the acid level is unknown; this means boiling water canning might not be safe unless bottled lemon juice or vinegar is added in a tested amount. Otherwise, freezing or refrigeration is safer.

*Source: PNW 395 Salsa recipes for canning*

# SAFE

Low-acid foods like potatoes must be processed in a properly operated pressure canner to reach 240°F and kill Clostridium botulinum spores. Using a tested recipe with correct pressure, time, and altitude adjustments ensures safety. An accurate gauge ensures the correct temperature is reached and maintained during the entire process.

*Source: PNW 361 Canning meat poultry game*

# NOT SAFE

Garlic in oil is a low-acid, anaerobic environment ideal for Clostridium botulinum growth if not acidified or refrigerated. Storing it at room temperature without acidification can lead to deadly botulism toxin formation, even if it looks and smells normal.

*Source: PNW 450 Canning smoked fish at home*

# IT DEPENDS

Vegetable soups with meat are low-acid foods that require pressure canning to reach 240°F to kill botulism spores. Boiling water canning (212°F) is insufficient. Safety depends on whether the recipe is research-tested for boiling water canning (rare for such soups). Without tested instructions, pressure canning is mandatory. Altitude and jar size also affect processing time.

*Source: PNW 421 Use care operation of your pressure canner*

# SAFE

Using vinegar with 5% acidity ensures the proper acidity level to prevent botulism and other pathogens. Following a tested recipe and processing times adjusted for altitude ensures the pickles reach a temperature that kills harmful organisms. Fresh spices enhance flavor without impacting safety, and proper water bath canning seals the jars, preventing contamination.

*Source: NCHFP Pickled eggs*

# NOT SAFE

Homemade vinegar can vary widely in acidity, which makes it impossible to guarantee food safety. Skipping processing prevents killing harmful bacteria or sealing out new contamination. Storing unsealed jars at room temperature allows growth of pathogens like Clostridium botulinum, risking botulism.

*Source: PNW 355 Pickling vegetables*

# IT DEPENDS

Soaking cucumbers in pickling lime can help maintain firmness but it is essential to remove all excess lime by multiple rinses and soakings. If lime residue remains, it can raise the pH, making the pickles unsafe by allowing harmful bacteria to grow. Safety depends on thorough rinsing and following recipe directions exactly.

*Source: PNW 355 Pickling vegetables*

# SAFE

Elderberry jams require precise ratios of sugar to fruit and correct heat processing to prevent bacterial growth. This recipe uses enough sugar to lower water activity and processing time adjusted for altitude ensures safety. Following a tested recipe with these steps prevents foodborne illness.

*Source: EM 9446 Playing it safe when preserving elderberries*

# NOT SAFE

Processing time must increase with altitude because water boils at lower temperatures at higher elevations. Using the low-altitude time at 5,500 feet means the jam was underprocessed, risking spoilage and botulism. Always follow altitude-adjusted times to ensure safety.

*Source: EM 9446 Playing it safe when preserving elderberries*

# IT DEPENDS

Reducing sugar in traditional jam recipes without using low-sugar pectin or altering acid levels can result in unsafe jam because sugar preserves and helps gel formation. Safety depends on using tested recipes designed for low sugar and following processing instructions precisely.

*Source: SP 50-632 Making berry syrups at home*

# SAFE

Freezing cooked food in shallow containers with appropriate headspace allows for rapid cooling and prevents unsafe temperature ranges that promote bacteria growth. Keeping the freezer at 0°F (-18°C) or below maintains food safety and quality. Labeling and dating packages helps rotate and use food within recommended times to maintain quality.

*Source: PNW 296 Freezing convenience foods that you've prepared at home*

# NOT SAFE

Freezing can cause jars to crack or seals to break, allowing contamination. Consuming food from cracked jars without reheating can cause foodborne illness. Canned goods should not freeze; if they do, evaluate jars carefully and boil low-acid foods for 10 minutes before use to ensure safety. If jars are cracked or seals broken and food has thawed at room temperature, discard immediately.

*Source: PNW 296 Freezing convenience foods that you've prepared at home*

# IT DEPENDS

Seafood freezes safely at 0°F, but large, deep containers freeze more slowly, allowing bacteria growth during prolonged cooling. Frequent temperature fluctuations above 5°F may compromise safety. If the stew was cooled quickly to 0°F or below and has remained frozen, it is safe. If thawing occurred or temperatures rose above 40°F for significant time, safety is compromised. Always consider how quickly food was frozen and the freezer temperature history.

*Source: PNW 586 Home freezing seafood*

# SAFE

Maintaining a drying temperature of at least 145°F, preferably around 155°F, and following a tested recipe ensures that harmful bacteria are killed during jerky preparation. Using a dehydrator with a thermostat and verifying the actual temperature helps guarantee safety. This method aligns with OSU Extension recommendations for safe jerky drying.

*Source: PNW 632 Making jerky at home safely*

# NOT SAFE

Cold smoking does not cook fish and does not reliably kill harmful bacteria or parasites. Without further cooking or preservation steps like freezing or curing, storing cold-smoked fish at room temperature risks foodborne illness. Proper hot-smoking or following tested preservation methods is necessary for safety.

*Source: PNW 238 Smoking fish at home*

# IT DEPENDS

Drying times and temperatures sometimes need adjustment based on altitude (typically above 1,000 feet) due to lower air pressure affecting water evaporation. At higher elevations like 3,000 feet, longer drying times or slightly higher temperatures may be needed to ensure food safety and prevent spoilage. Morgan should consult altitude-specific guidelines to be sure.

*Source: PNW 397 Drying fruits and vegetables*